

A nose for food

Most omnivorous mammals are active after dark and track down food by its smell. Wild boar search for food mainly at dusk and dawn. They use smell to find acorns and berries among fallen leaves and hunt small animals, such as mice, birds, and beetles.

They also sniff out food that is hidden underground. A wild boar's snout works like a shovel, pushing aside the soil so that it can get at roots, fungi, grubs, and worms, as well as dead remains. In times of food shortage, they can dig up farmed crops such as corn.



Not too picky

Together with their close relatives—ravens, jays, and magpies—crows are intelligent birds with an appetite for all kinds of food. Crows cannot chew, so they must smash many meals, such as this turtle, on hard objects, or swallow them whole. Compared to mammals, crows have a poor sense of smell and find their food by sight. They raid the nests of other birds to eat their eggs and young, and they like to steal bright or shiny objects that catch their eye.



*Young redbelly
crow with
hard shell*

*Powerful jaws help
to break through
body armor*

*Cricket turned on
its back to reveal
soft body parts*



Space invaders

Many omnivorous mammals live in built-up areas, or even inside buildings. Aside from insects, the most successful of these omnivores are mammals. They can live alongside people without being seen, because they are mainly active at night. Humans can find raccoons and foxes a nuisance, because they upturn garbage cans and make a mess, but rats are a more serious problem, since they can spread disease.

Brown rat

The brown rat lives all over the world. Its favorite foods include grain and other seeds, but it eats all kinds of other things, from chicken bones to soap. Brown rats can breed all year round if they have enough food.



Raccoon

In North America, the raccoon sorts through garbage using its small but sensitive front paws. Its natural habitat is woodland, and it thrives in built-up areas wherever there are trees. In addition to eating leftovers, it digs up garden plants and pulls fish out of backyard ponds.



Red fox

Urban foxes are widespread in Europe and North America, even in busy city centers. Moving briskly, they can cover up to 6 miles (10 km) a night in their search for food. Red foxes usually forage after dark, but they often stay up after dawn before returning to their dens.



Animal cannibals

Most predators instinctively avoid targeting their own kind as prey. But some omnivores are not so particular—given an opportunity, they sometimes attack, kill, and eat each other. This Mormon cricket, of the deserts of North America, has done exactly that, and is halfway through its gruesome meal. Mormon crickets usually feed on plants, but they turn on one another if they swarm and start to run out of food. This kind of cannibalism is rare, but many more omnivores—such as slugs—eat the already dead remains of their own kind.